

THE WORLD DOESN'T MAKE ANY HEROES OUTSIDE OF YOUR STORIES

THE THIRD MAN / 1949

IN CONTEXT

GENRE

Film noir

DIRECTOR

Carol Reed

WRITER

Graham Greene

STARS

Joseph Cotten, Alida Valli, Orson Welles, Trevor Howard

BEFORE

1941 The film noir genre is established by US movies such as *The Maltese Falcon*.

1941 With *Citizen Kane*, Orson Welles establishes a film-noir staple—the narrative voice-over.

AFTER

1951 Welles revives his Third Man character on radio in *The Adventures of Harry Lime*.

Carol Reed's 1949 film noir *The Third Man* captured Europe's fractured spirit after World War II. Unusually for the time, Reed shot it in partly on location, in bomb-damaged Vienna. Dramatic pools of light and shade, and tilted camera angles, turn the city into a nightmarish setting for the tale of racketeer Harry Lime,

played by Orson Welles. Echoing through it all is the haunting zither music of Anton Karas, whom Reed found while shooting in Vienna.

The movie was hugely popular in Britain, but fared poorly in Austria. To Austrian audiences, it was a painful reminder of a troubled past.

